

He tried jogging and working out to relieve the stress. For emotional support he leaned on his wife and 14-year-old son. He tried to replace his spent staff with better people. But he could see himself slipping. He began to drink, have funny stomach pains that puzzled doctors, and wake up sweating at four in the morning. By five o'clock on workdays he was as irritable as a saber-tooth tiger with a toothache.

At about that time, he inherited the house he was living in. Also at about that time, his last healthy department head quit. My friend decided enough was enough. He went to see the chairman, with the idea of quitting, and came out with a one-year leave of absence. He rented out his house for \$2,000 a month, pulled his daughter out of school and his wife out of the doldrums, and flew off to Europe.

The three of them learned firsthand that the English heat their buildings to freezing, that the French bathe only every three months or so, that the Spanish hoard information, and that most of Italy stays closed most of the time. They made new friends, got a more rounded view of life, and learned to swear at waiters in three languages. They grew as a family. My friend remembered how to laugh without having a couple of pops at the bar beforehand. His stomach pains went away and he started doing sit-ups in hotel rooms instead of lifting weights at a gym.

At the end of the year the family returned home. My friend was a new man. He knew he could handle his old job but he had little desire to do so. Pushing numbers seemed irrelevant. He felt more like starting something new.

Before going to the office to discuss it with his boss he put together some figures and discovered his family's net worth had *increased*. They had spent \$1,600 a month in Europe—just over \$50 a day. But they had rented out their home for \$2,000. After taxes and expenses they had cash left over to cover inflation. The best year of their lives had cost them nothing.

My friend called his old boss and resigned. He bought a